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Ira Gitler

Ira Gitler is one of America's most respected jazz historians and writers. As a native of New York City, he grew up surrounded by jazz and the influential musicians who created it. After completing his education at the University of Mississippi and Columbia University, he worked for Prestige Records and helped this label become an important home for jazz during the fifties. His work with Leonard Feather on the Encyclopedia of Jazz *was followed by writing assignments for* Down Beat and Metronome. *Ira has written scripts for documentaries on Lionel Hampton and Louis Armstrong. Currently Ira holds the position of Jazz Historian at the Manhattan School of Music.*

Mr. Gitler was interviewed by Michael Woods in New York City on November 16, 1995.

MW: We are here in New York City and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. We have with us today one of our country's finest jazz historians, Ira Gitler. Pleased to have you.

IG: Good to see you.

MW: I want to open with a question and ask you why is jazz history important?

IG: Well it's important because the music is important so we should keep track of what happened and, you know, the lives of the musicians and the breadth of the music over the years. But also because of the way it ties in with our culture. It's so part of our culture, and it's been such a great — not just an entertainment and an artistic enjoyment, but it's been a way of bringing people together and enlightening people about people. Because let's face it, jazz began as an Afro-American expression, and because of what the great musicians of that tradition put down in the twenties and the thirties and even before, it opened the eyes and minds as well as the ears to people of other persuasions and it showed something of the humanity and the intellect of these people, where ordinarily some other people might not have made this connection.

MW: You know one of the early figures that began to get people's attention that this was more than entertainment and there was some incredible craft involved was Louis Armstrong.

IG: Absolutely.

MW: Tell us what he did for the trumpet and what he did for jazz.

IG: Well I mean there had been soloists before, powerful soloists, of course we've all heard about Buddy Bolden and the cylinder, the Edison cylinder that's never been found, but you know the people who played with him survived to talk about him and how powerful he was and great in his own way. But in listening to the records of the people who came up with him and started to record, and then you hear Louis Armstrong, he was really the

first great soloist in the music, using an incredible technique and power to bring forth the product of a mind that thought not only very musically but very humanly because I think he embodied all the feelings that people have. He stirred those feelings up, with just a phrase or a note or his rhythm. He did it all. And he really freed up I think the other musicians to think in a broader way, that they could do more. Not necessarily just the bravura thing, which he had, but that he was also telling a story, playing melodies that were just delightful. You know you didn't have to ask why you were smiling or feeling good. And I think he did all these things. He was literally a giant and genius. We all toss that around a little too much but he was.

MW: You know this is something I also want you to comment on. You know at the time that Louis was in his heyday one of the things that many students going to music schools now don't realize, there were no method books.

IG: Well there was the Arban book I guess, I don't know when that came in, you know.

MW: Well that didn't explain any jazz harmonies though.

IG: No, no, it just was for technique. No. I think he listened and he heard, and most of the great musicians, no matter how much training they have and put that in their service, it's the intuitive and what they soak up and play back at you. You know Charlie Parker was amazing the way he would hear fragments of songs or whole songs, and incorporate them. He just was omnivorous in his listening, you could see. And an incredible retentive memory, as we know from the way he would change his solos from take to take on a particular number. But I don't know if I talked about this when I was up to your class, but it was something I discovered a couple of years ago, that his "Steeple Chase," the theme of his song "Steeple Chase" was taken from a riff that was used behind Trummy Young's vocal of "Margie" with Jimmie Lunceford. And it was a record that sold a lot of copies and had a lot of exposure, and everyone who came up in that period heard it, and obviously Charlie Parker heard it too, and it was just a little phrase that they play when he's taking a breath. And Charlie Parker took that phrase and, you know, made a whole tune out of it. That's just one little example. So I think, getting back to Louis Armstrong, I think he heard all the music that was happening around him. Ragtime, the blues, opera, you know, light classical as they used to call it, and the classics. But I think opera was very popular then and I think a lot of people heard operatic themes and in fact I think some of those type of pieces were used as things to warm up on, you know to practice with. 'Cause there's a record called "Laughin' Louie," I don't know if you know that record, it's a novelty, and Louis' having a good time in the studio with everybody and people are cracking up in between, after the vocal, and then he says, "Here's one of those good old good ones," and no one's ever been able to tell me what it is and I don't know.

But it kind of has that semi-classical as we used to call it, light opera or whatever, it's a theme like that. And he plays that and does a lot of miraculous things with it.

MW: I want to ask you a thing about him. They say that when Louis Armstrong took a solo it seemingly always had this wonderful finished quality. It wasn't as if he rambled or was hunting for notes. It's like when he got to the end it almost had this feeling of almost inevitable correctness.

IG: Well I think a lot of the players then, once they got a certain chorus, remember in-person I don't know how long they played, but I think I tend to believe that other than at jam sessions, the live performances were a lot like the recordings, you know, just a couple of choruses. Maybe they stretched a little bit more, but I think once they got a chorus they liked, they kind of stayed with that. Now we have alternate takes of things he's done and they do vary, but they always have certain elements in them, you know I guess something he liked and so I guess he kept it in. And I think he had a great sense of form. But after his period with the Hot Fives and Hot Sevens, when he led his own band or fronted Luis Russell's band in the thirties made a whole gang of records for Decca, which only recently have begun to be recognized as classics, people dismiss them, you know they're not that commercial. You know I don't know what commercial means in that sense, because the tunes may have been pop tunes, but whatever he did with them was transcendent and you find that he had a formula. The first chorus he would play the straight melody, then he would embellish it in the second, then he would, you know, become a little more adventurous in the third chorus and the fourth chorus maybe he'd reach that climactic thing where he ascended into the stratosphere and just made it a grand finish. So it was always, I think he always had a sense of form.

MW: Tracing the lineage from that, from that trumpet player to another all-time favorite of mine, tell us what you know about Dizzy.

IG: Well Dizzy I always say was one-half of my heartbeat and Charlie Parker was the other, but there are a lot of other people too, Lester Young especially and Coleman Hawkins, people like that. And many, many others. But I discovered Dizzy and Charlie Parker when I was in high school and I had already been listening to jazz for a long time, but they hit me like a revelation. I became really a fanatic about them. I tried to convert everyone I met, "You've got to listen to this." And I've told this story a number of times but the first time I heard Dizzy, and I wasn't aware of him in Cab Calloway's band although I must have heard him, because my brother, among other records he collected, he loved Lunceford and Goodman and Basie especially, but he also collected Cab Calloway records. So I must have heard Dizzy without knowing it. But the first time I was aware of it was a radio broadcast on a D.J. show. There was the 1280 Club in New York on WOV, a guy named Alan Courtney, who played very good music. And one night

a week in the course of his program he would go to a live wire from some club. And this was a club on 52nd Street. In going back and doing some research, I learned it was The Onyx, and there was Dizzy and Oscar Pettiford and that, what is called the first bebop band to play, you know, as a cohesive unit, with heads that were very typical of the music as it was developing at that time. And I heard this guy playing the trumpet who was announced as Dizzy Gillespie, and I said it sounds like he's playing some wrong notes, but he's interesting, you know, there's something about him that was intriguing. And I didn't hear him again until I heard him on record. And at that time I think it was "Groovin' High," with Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie, and Bird hit me right away. I mean I just, you know, said what is this, it's fantastic. And I got what Dizzy was doing also at the same time. And so you know they became like twin idols to me, and when Bird and Dizzy went to California to play at Billy Berg's in December of 1945, I had not yet heard them in person. I wasn't really hanging out on 52nd Street regularly until towards the end of '45, and they had done their famous run at the Three Deuces in May and then recorded the famous sessions for Guild, "Hot House" and "Shaw Nuff" and all that stuff. So I hadn't heard them in person. But I was listening to all their records. And then of course the California trip was a disaster. Only the musicians were really picking up on them and the public was really not ready for them. And Dizzy came back, Bird stayed on in California. And Dizzy opened at the Spotlight Club in 1946, I think it was March, with a small band with Leo Parker on baritone in place of Charlie Parker, no relation. And I went down to hear them. And you know it just knocked me out. And the first piece of writing that I ever did on jazz that was published was in my high school newspaper, about Dizzy Gillespie at the Spotlight Club. And you know the atmosphere on 52nd Street was marvelous because once you got down there and your face became familiar, you became part of the scenery. It was almost like a stage set. It was two blocks between Fifth and Seventh Avenues. But particularly between Fifth and Sixth, that was the real concentration. But even before you were known, the musicians were very open and I remember Dizzy came by our table and I said, "When are you going to record again?" And he said, "We recorded today." You know he had that little kind of sandpapery voice. And it turned out that was what they called the "New 52nd Street" jazz album on RCA, February 22 or something like that. And so he had recorded that day and we heard him that night. And he was an incredible personality. It was incorporated into his playing. But it was like all one, much like the other giants in the music, but some of them were more sober-sided you know, not voluble or being able to incorporate the entertainment with the high artistic quality of the music. With Dizzy you got all of that, like with Louis Armstrong. And he just was electric. You know the fact that he was doing all of these new things, of course, these cascades of notes and the high register work and

then the pretty ballads. But he was a personality. He was zany, you know, he was everything. But as he once said, "Yeah you know they say that I kid around too much and all that" he says. "but in the music I'm serious." And some people failed to get past the other part. They only saw the beret and the goatee and the heavy rimmed glasses, and you know Dizzy. But I thought Teddy Hill said it best I think, his ex-leader, he said, "Dizzy like a fox."

MW: You know, he was always on top of his playing.

IG: So he was always one of my heroes.

MW: I want to talk about another aspect here. Of course we're doing our archive here principally based upon the life of Joe Williams and the chronology of the Count Basie band. And I'd like for you to just give us some insights into how the Kansas City scene that spawned some of the great midwestern territory bands and eventually of course the great Count Basie band, how that would have been different from what was happening on either coast, and some of its distinctives.

IG: Well I think it had a lot of the same ingredients that were in the other regional jazzes, if we can say that, but I think their blues were a little different kind of blues and I think eventually they ended up calling it "urban blues" as opposed to "country blues." But it was the rhythm. The way they smoothed out the rhythm. They got that four-four like it was on ball bearings or big rubber tires or something, but it flowed in a way that no other jazz flowed, and I think it had an infectious feeling to it. And all those bands out there had that thing. And I think it was just like in many other situations where jazz flourished and grew, there were a lot of venues for musicians to play. And it was like a happening scene. And the jam sessions went on, sometimes the performances were like jam sessions, they just went on all night. And so I think when the Basie band started, it came out of other bands as we know, Walter Page's Blue Devils and Bennie Moten's band, and it was formed by musicians who had played with one another, who were comfortable with one another, who thought alike, and it was very unpretentious and very spontaneous. You know the original Basie band was made up mostly of head arrangements, they didn't have anything written down, and it just developed that way. And fortunately they had some incredible soloists, each one with a distinctive voice, sometimes two on the same instrument who were opposites and yet compatible, like Herschel Evans and Lester Young on tenors and Buck Clayton and Harry "Sweets" Edison on trumpets and a lot of other players, you know Hot Lips Page was in at the beginning before they came to New York. But that band just had a special cachet. And I have to speak personally about it because when I started listening to jazz, I was what, you know six, seven, eight years old, because it was the music you heard on the radio and when you went to a stage show you saw a swing band and it was the Swing Era. And my brother was a great fan of this music

and probably his favorite band was the Basie band. So that was what I cut my teeth on, among other bands. And I remember him telling me, "Listen to the way Lester Young starts the band off on 'Every Tub.'" Because he had the first lick before the band even came in. And my brother was twelve years older than I was and you know, he was like a second father in a way. He used to take me out with his friends and, you know, I looked up to him and I found that this interest he had touched me. I didn't have to think twice about it. It got me in my soul. And he belonged to a young folks league which did charity raising for an orphanage. And every Sunday afternoon they'd have a dance over at the orphanage and they'd play all these records and dance to them. Well Christmas 1938 they hired the Basie band to play at the Manhattan Center in New York as their big fundraiser. And I remember waiting for him to get up that next morning so he could tell me about actually seeing all these people that I'd been listening to on record. So the Basie band is very special to me. And I cherish those early records. And you know they always say that's the Old Testament band, and then the band that he formed after he had the sextet for a brief time in 1950, when he started up the band again in '51, that's called the New Testament band. And they had, in common, the incredible swing, and Freddie Green that made the transition. They tell the story that when Basie formed the sextet, he was opening at the Capitol Lounge I think in Chicago and he hadn't notified Freddie Green, he hadn't hired him. And Freddie Green just came there, plugged in his amplifier and he was there. So naturally Basie had to hire him.

MW: What are you going to do, tell him to go home?

IG: No way. And he was like the core of that rhythm section, which they call the All-American Rhythm Section, and it was. So he was the constant. He went from the original band to the sextet, octet, whatever it happened to be at the time, and then the new band, which of course is where Joe Williams comes in.

MW: That's where I was going, that's where I was going next. Talk to us about Joe as a singer, as a cultural icon as well.

IG: Well it's interesting, but I was shuffling through some LPs the other night because my wife had to clean out a certain section, you know, "We've got to clean out, there's too much dust over there, get these LPs out" and it happened to be the end of V through Z. And so I was looking through them naturally after we got them out. And here was Joe Williams, it's a Savoy LP, I don't know if it's been re-issued on CD, and it had some of his early work, pre-Basie. And there's a version of "Every Day" on there and it points out that he did this and the thing did nothing. So you know everything has its time and its presentation and everything came together when he made that recording with Basie. Of course I think it was Ernie Wilkin's arrangement if I'm not mistaken, Frank Foster plays behind him, like beautiful obbligati, and the band is kicking and the thing took off. And

that really helped establish that band because the R & B shows, the D.J.s were playing Basie and the young kids started to listen to this band. It wasn't played just on jazz shows, because of some of the things they did. And I remember because I was working for Prestige Records at the time and we had to monitor Tommy "Dr. Jive" Smalls. He was the D.J. on WWRL out in Long Island. And they were slipping him five or ten dollars to play some of the Prestige numbers, right? So we had to, while we were packing boxes and stuff, we had to listen to see if he was playing it. Well naturally you heard everything else: B.B. King doing the "Three O'clock Blues" and Count Basie with Joe Williams doing "Every Day." And so that really helped put that band over. He was a very important part of that band. And of course continuing on with a number of things he did that were all big, "The Comeback" and a lot of different things. And then of course he branched out and I started to see him in another light, his ability as an actor. And of course that helps him to this day to present his songs, because he really puts a lot of other ingredients into it than just singing. He's definitely an actor. And when I saw him on stage at the Newport Jazz Festival in New York, I guess this was in the early seventies when it came from Newport and settled in New York, Cannonball Adderley and Joe combine on a thing, it was like the legend of John Henry. I think it was called "Big Man" if I'm not mistaken. And Joe's ability as an actor that I had always seen really came to the fore. And I'm surprised that nobody ever took advantage of putting him in a musical, because he could have carried this off grandly, both as an actor and as a singer. You know I used to think this about Sarah Vaughan. I don't know if she could have handled the acting, but I would have loved to have heard her in a Broadway musical just to hear her singing on stage in a certain setting. But he definitely could have done it. And of course later he shows up on the Cosby Show as the grandfather, and you know he's marvelous. He's got humor, he's got pathos, he's got all the attributes that an actor has to have. And whenever you see him in performance, these things come out and he puts those songs over, he gets to the audience, you know, just in an ungimmicked way. Because it's all, again, getting back to Dizzy and Louis Armstrong, it's all part of the persona. It's all one thing. It's not just this is sticking out and saying oh boy, he's doing this.

MW: It's not contrived.

IG: No.

MW: You know I wanted to ask you something about that. We talk about stage presence. Can stage presence be taught or is it something you have to absorb from culture?

IG: I think it depends on the individual. You know everybody learns it in one way or another. So I think if the subject is receptive, then it can be taught to him or to her. But a lot of people just pick it up by what they have lived.

MW: What can young singers today learn from the example of a Joe Williams?

IG: Well they can't learn to have some innate musicality which I think he had. Because one of my bêtes noires is all these singers, and it happens to be more on the female side just because there are more female singers, but they all think they can scat. And you know there is some sad scatting. Because they think all you have to do is do some rhythmic phrases and you're scatting. No, you have to sing some melodies as if you were playing a horn. You have to improvise. And you know, Joe Williams, quiet as it's kept, can scat. You know he doesn't do it that often, but you know, and his musicality comes out in another way there. And I think maybe they can learn that from him. They certainly have to learn that just going "oobie doobie do" does not get it.

MW: You know I've been in some scenarios in which they try to teach jazz vocals and they take, they just have all these almost contrived syllables. And it just doesn't take on any authenticity.

IG: Well everybody has their own syllables. Some people favor the S sibilance and other people, like Dave Lambert used to sing with V's, "oh-V-oh-V-oh-V-oh-V-oh" and other people use Bs and whatever works. But you know you have to be telling a story, just as you would on an instrument, because it is your instrument. But I think you can teach jazz up to a point. Well you know, you teach it. But you can only lead them so far. And then something else has to take over.

MW: They say you can lead a sax man to water but you can't make him gig.

IG: What did Charlie Parker say? Learn everything you can possibly learn, and then forget about it and play. Yeah, well because hopefully you've gotten it to a place where you don't have to think about it because you know it. And then you let your instincts take over.

MW: I want to ask you about another major figure that I don't think we've really talked about in depth in any of our interviews so far. And I want to talk about it culturally and spiritually because he had those aspects to his character. Tell us about Coltrane.

IG: Well Coltrane was a serious man. I don't say he didn't laugh and didn't have his own sense of humor, I really didn't see it personally although I spent some time with him, in fact I heard him a lot. But you know he wasn't a great conversationalist. Probably if I'd gotten to know him a little better. But I did interview him for a *Down Beat* article. I wrote the first article about him in a major publication or in any publication I think of any length. And at that time he was between apartments and he was staying at the Park Central Hotel, which later became the Park Sheraton and I think it's the Park Central again, I can't keep up with it. Like WHN and WMGM in New York. And so I went up to his room, and you know it was a time when I was working with Prestige as a writer. I wasn't there every day anymore, but I had been there in the period when he came with

Miles and then became a recording leader in his own right there. And we hung out and talked, and he was very warm and very serious and you know I think a man, at that time, very aware that some people were misinterpreting him. He had been called an "angry young tenor" or something in *Down Beat* and he said, "I'm only angry at myself when I don't make what I'm trying to do." But he was a very spiritual person, there's no doubt about that. You got that from him. And he battled a lot of demons, and came through it, but it took its toll. And I think about Trane, I think a lot of people talk about his great spirituality in his later work, you know when he really became very pointed towards the spiritual. But he always had it, even when he wasn't playing "A Love Supreme" or post that, and I think everything he played when it was a ballad it was a very spiritual feeling.

MW: It was still there in the sound.

IG: Yeah. He had a distinct sound, there's no doubt about that. And that's something every musician strives for is to get that recognizable, that individual sound. And he had it of course, and everybody who's coming behind him figuring boy this sounds good, I'm going to play like that, which is what always happens. Some did it and brought something of themselves to it and others didn't.

MW: Some people say it's not wise to look for a man's predecessor amongst his imitators.

IG: Well you know sometimes he influenced people who already had established styles too. He was such a powerful force. It wasn't just the people who came up behind him, it was some of the people that were already there. And then they had to come to a maybe a rapprochement between what they had been before they heard him and what he gave them and then they kind of sorted it out and then went back to being themselves and retaining something of him.

MW: I have a couple more questions I want to ask you. We talk about culture and you early on talked about African-American culture and how that it had, it gave something to jazz. Okay, where is it now and can it revitalize itself? I say this in lieu of the march, the Million Man March. 'Cause that to me represented something perhaps maybe trying to come back together. Will that surface in music in some way, in jazz?

IG: Well I think it has surfaced in jazz because I've written about this also and no one has really picked up on it. I thought that the continuity of jazz in the black community was kind of co-opted by radio and television. I don't say that rhythm & blues wasn't great, I used to enjoy it very much, and other forms of black music, of course Gospel, if you're not moved by that I think you're ready for the grave. You know there's all forms. But there are certain commercialized musics in, you know, coming from all areas in American life where everything becomes more of a manufactured quality and because it is the thing that's making money, that's what's played on the radio. And I called it kind of a cultural genocide, when jazz was just wiped off the radio. I used to go into black

communities when I was in college and in my post-college years, and connect with people because we all had the same records and we were listening to the music together and all that. And then I found more and more that the young black people coming up didn't know anything about jazz because they didn't hear it anymore. And the advent of Wynton Marsalis has brought, as you know, a raft of great young black musicians. They weren't coming to the music, not only was the black community not listening to it, but as a result we weren't getting any young black musicians that were really playing it. And since Wynton came up, he didn't do it alone, but he is in great part responsible for it. When he and his brother Branford came with Art Blakey and people heard them, and young musicians, or young black people who maybe hadn't even thought about taking up instruments, were inspired because they saw someone who was a contemporary playing this music and looking sharp, and so from that time on, the eighties and nineties, look at all the great young talents that we have. And I know the argument has been made, oh they're just doing that same old thing, they're doing that old music. Yeah, but they've gotten back to some of the truths of this music, you know the traditions of this music. And I'm a great believer of tradition. And yeah, maybe they're playing the music of Louis Armstrong and Jelly Roll Morton and Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie and John Coltrane and Mingus and whatever, and the whole history of the music. And I think that's important. And I think that's where we have a new beginning. There I feel was a mini-renaissance, and I think we'll take it from there. And they're not just imitating. They're learning and they're putting their own spin on it because there are other things in the air than what was in the air when those musics were made. So it's got to be a little different. And you know, I'm the boring old college professor that has his certain pet stories, and this one is the one I use. I say it's like a plant. If you cut it back it's the same plant but it might grow with a different configuration. And I think this is what's happened. When you go back to those roots of this music and all the giants, so you're really in essence you're cutting it back and then it's going to grow again in a new way, and who knows what it's going to lead to this time? Because it kind of almost got lost. It never got completely lost because there were people playing it, and people listening to it. In fact the old records were always selling. You know every generation they reissue the, just for an example, The Miles Davis Quintet on Prestige, and every new generation buys these, now in CD, before they bought the LP reissue, the two-for or whatever it was. You know it's a new configuration. And so the music is constantly fresh to a new generation. Because they didn't hear it before. And where they're going to take it we don't know, but that's the interesting part.

MW: Can — and this is kind of a follow-up — can jazz, you know for instance we talk about the big band period and we say how two great things, people were dancing and people were listening on the radio. Can jazz ever become America's popular music again?

IG: Looking at it right now, I don't think so, but who knows? That was a particular time, if you're talking about big bands, you know economically it's not feasible. In fact if you have a sextet and you want to book it, you're probably better off cutting it back to a quintet because you might have a better chance, right? And big bands exist now in little places once a week or some bands have existed getting bookings, you know going to Europe and Japan and all that, but the big band is not a viable thing. Once ballrooms ceased and theater stage shows and hotel rooms where bands played, you know the venues dried up. And if you are a club owner, you put a big band in and you have a bigger nut to cover. I heard Jimmy Heath's big band recently, which is not together all the time by any means, and they played over at the Iridium, one of New York's newer clubs, it's only been a couple of years. And I'm sure that everybody was making scale, they weren't making a lot of money, but it took a lot of courage to put a big band in there for a week, and people dug it, and I think they're going to go back in. There's nothing quite like a big band in full roar, and you can't duplicate that. But I don't think it's going to come back in the same way. There's no reason why people can't dance to smaller combos. We used to have that. The people danced and the people that didn't want to dance got up around the bandstand and listened, even at jam sessions, which I used to go to a lot in the forties. They had chairs set up in the back, these were organized jam sessions, a Sunday afternoon gig, that was the typical, traditional time for that, Sunday afternoon, late afternoon into early evening. And they'd set up chairs towards the back of the ballroom and leave space in the front for people to dance. So it was just the opposite of when you went to hear a big band and people danced in the back and people crowded up around the bandstand to listen. They pre-figured this.

MW: Yeah, I wanted to ask you perhaps maybe just one last question here and that is you know students hopefully, the students even at our college and perhaps even other colleges, will see these tapes. Tell us a few things that students should know about jazz, other than just the names and dates.

IG: Well the names and dates are things that you latch on to once you get interested in a particular band or a particular musician and so you want to know when this happened, how it happened, etcetera, etcetera. But I think the thing to do is keep your ears open and listen, and listen as much as you can. And the more you listen, the more knowledgeable you become and the more sophisticated in your listening, and you're able to make judgments and comparisons, and also to understand your taste. Because everyone's taste is different, but you kind of begin to see what you like more and one recording may lead

you to another and then it's like I had a friend who liked jazz but he wasn't avidly as into it as myself, and he took Slam Stewart — he loved Slam Stewart singing and bowing the bass at the same time. Everybody kind of could get with that. And because he liked Slam and I played the record of "Groovin' High" which I spoke of before for him, and Slam plays on that. So he bought that because of Slam. And then he said to me, "Wow, Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie." So Slam Stewart really opened that other thing up for him. And you know, just keep your ears open and listen, and as we used to say reading movie criticism when we were teenagers, after you get to know your critics, the same thing in jazz, you know what to expect from them and you know when and who will say something that you can rely on. But you have to use your own ears basically, just use that as a guide. You know you have to listen for yourself. The more you listen the more you know and the more you'll enjoy it.

MW: Two things real fast, real fast. You're doing some work, being asked to provide information for scripts for a documentary is that right? On Louis and on Hamp?

IG: No, I did that years ago.

MW: Okay, tell us how that was for you, you know, providing the facts — helping to provide the facts for a documentary like that.

IG: Well I just did my research, you know, starting with my own experience, my own knowledge of it up to that point, and then you just delve in and read as much as you can and if you're able to talk to some of the musicians who were there, I think that's very important. We have some great sources of information and expertise, people that were actually there and did it who are still alive. Milt Hinton and Doc Cheatham and people like this, who can tell us things that we don't know first hand. Just as I can tell things first-hand because I was there at a certain time in the history of the music. And so whenever you can avail yourselves of the actual musicians, I think it's very important to do that.

MW: Well thank you so much, and we're going to kind of wrap up here and thank you for coming and sharing some very precious insights about some of our major icons in this idiom, and we hope that this, not only this taping of this particular session, but the information that you're telling finds its way into the hearts of students who are interested in this art form.

IG: Thank you Michael.